

HOLD-UP AT 3NT

South opens 1NT (15-17 balanced), North raises to 3NT.

Teaching feature: declarer has exactly ONE stopper in hearts (the Ace).

WEST — the opening leader — has a 5-card heart suit headed by KQ and leads it. East has only 2-3 hearts but holds the side-suit entry declarer must knock out.

If declarer wins the first heart, then knocks out East's entry, East still has a heart to return and West cashes the long suit — 3NT goes down.

The hold-up technique: refuse to win the early heart tricks. Duck until EAST (the hand with the entry) is OUT of hearts, then win the Ace. Now when declarer drives out East's entry, East has no heart to return — West's established hearts are stranded with no way back in.

Things to think about:

- How many times should you duck? Just enough to exhaust East's hearts.
- After ducking, where will you take your remaining tricks?
- Lose the lead only to East (safe once they are out of hearts); keep West, with the long suit and no entry, off lead.

Reference: https://www.bridgebum.com/hold-up_play.php